

ESSENTIAL SKILL

First Aid & Medicine

Stop the Immediate Problem. Get Help
When Needed.

Small injuries can become serious when ignored. Basic first aid helps control bleeding, protect wounds, cool burns, recognize danger, and keep a problem from becoming worse until proper care is available.

PROTECT LIFE. CONTROL THE PROBLEM. GET HELP.

FIRST: IS IT AN EMERGENCY?

Call 911 or local emergency services when available

Not breathing normally

Unresponsive

Severe bleeding

Serious chest pain

Signs of stroke

Severe breathing difficulty

Major, chemical, or electrical burns

Serious head or spinal injury

IMMEDIATE ACTION

If someone is unresponsive and not breathing normally, call for help, begin CPR, and use an AED according to your training and the device prompts. Do not delay emergency care to keep reading.

HEAVY BLEEDING CAN BECOME FATAL QUICKLY

Severe bleeding

1

Make it safe

Check the scene, call emergency services, and put on disposable gloves if available.

2

Find the source

Expose the wound enough to see where the blood is coming from. Do not remove an embedded object.

3

Apply pressure

Put clean gauze or cloth directly over the wound and press firmly and steadily.

4

Keep pressure

Do not repeatedly lift the original dressing to check. Maintain direct pressure until bleeding stops, trained help takes over, or the scene becomes unsafe.

5

Use trained skills

For life-threatening bleeding from an arm or leg, use a manufactured tourniquet if trained. Note the application time and do not loosen it.

SEVERE-BLEEDING RESPONSE

Call

Activate
emergency
help

**Locate**

Expose the
bleeding
source

**Press**

Firm pressure
with gauze or
cloth

**Hold**

Do not keep
lifting to check

Severe continuous or spurting bleeding requires immediate emergency medical treatment.

Small cuts and wounds

1

Clean hands

Wash your hands and use gloves when available.

2

Control bleeding

Use gentle direct pressure with clean gauze.

3

Rinse and cover

Rinse with clean water, remove only obvious surface dirt that comes away safely, and apply a clean dressing.

4

Monitor

Keep the wound clean and watch it over the following days.

Increasing redness

Swelling

Warmth

Pus

Increasing pain

Fever

Seek medical care for deep or badly contaminated wounds, animal bites, uncontrolled bleeding, loss of function, or signs of infection. Ask a clinician about tetanus protection when appropriate.

COOL IT, DO NOT CONTAMINATE IT

Minor thermal burns

1

Stop the burning

Move away from the heat source and make the scene safe.

2

Cool with water

Place the burn under clean, cool running water for 5 to 20 minutes. Do not use ice.

3

Remove loose items

Remove jewelry or loose clothing near the burn unless it is stuck to the skin.

4

Protect loosely

Use a clean, dry, non-adhesive dressing if needed.

Call emergency services for major burns. Seek urgent evaluation for chemical or electrical burns, deep burns, large areas, or burns of the face, mouth, neck, hands, feet, joints, or groin.

✗ Apply ice directly.

✗ Apply butter, grease, toothpaste, petroleum jelly, or other home remedies.

✗ Pull away clothing stuck to burned skin.

✗ Break blisters.

PROTECT THE INJURED AREA

Sprains and strains

Stop the activity, protect the injury, use a wrapped cold pack for short periods, elevate it if comfortable, and avoid unnecessary weight on a badly injured joint.

Seek medical care for severe pain, deformity, inability to use the limb, numbness, loss of circulation, or concern for a fracture.

RECOGNIZE THE WARNING SIGNS

Dehydration

Thirst

Dry mouth

Weakness

Dizziness

Dark urine

Reduced urination

Confusion

Fainting

Give safe fluids only when the person is awake, able to swallow, and not vomiting repeatedly. Severe dehydration, confusion, fainting, or inability to keep fluids down requires medical attention.

DAILY MEDICINE MAY BE LIFESAVING

Personal medications

Talk with a doctor or pharmacist about an appropriate emergency supply. Keep an up-to-date medication list with the drug name, purpose, dose, timing, allergies, medical conditions, pharmacy, and prescriber.

Protect the supply

Keep medicines in original labeled containers, stored dry and within the temperature limits on the label. Use a waterproof container if flooding or water damage is possible.

Medicines that need refrigeration

Some medicines, including certain insulin and liquid medicines, lose strength outside their required temperature range. Ask the pharmacist or manufacturer exactly how long each product can remain unrefrigerated.

☐ I know the labeled storage temperature and allowable time outside it.

☐ I have a cooler and cold packs suitable for the medicine.

☐ I can prevent the medicine from freezing or touching loose ice.

☐ I know where and how to obtain a replacement.

Do not guess whether a temperature-sensitive medicine is safe. Contact a pharmacist, healthcare professional, or manufacturer for product-specific instructions.

ONLY FAMILIAR AND APPROPRIATE PRODUCTS

Basic over-the-counter medicines

☐ Pain and fever medicine

☐ Antihistamine

☐ Antacid

☐ Antidiarrheal medicine

☐ Oral rehydration packets

☐ Other familiar household medicines

Read and follow labels. Check active ingredients to avoid accidental double dosing, and consider age, allergies, pregnancy, medical conditions, and drug interactions. Keep all medicine away from children.

DO NOT GUESS

What about antibiotics?

Antibiotics treat certain bacterial infections, not every illness. Do not use leftovers casually, share prescriptions, guess the drug or dose, or use antibiotics for viral illnesses.

Any antibiotic in an emergency plan should be selected and used under appropriate medical guidance.

KNOW YOUR PEOPLE

Identify essential medical needs

- Insulin
- Heart medicine
- Seizure medicine
- Blood thinners
- Asthma inhalers
- Epinephrine auto-injectors
- Oxygen
- Mobility equipment
- Hearing aids and batteries
- Other essential equipment

A community first-aid kit cannot replace someone's essential daily medicine.

RECOMMENDED SUPPLIES

Simple first-aid kit

☐ Disposable nonlatex gloves

☐ Sterile gauze and bandages

☐ Medical tape

☐ Antiseptic supplies

☐ Clean wound-rinsing water

☐ Elastic bandage

☐ Scissors and tweezers

☐ Cold packs

☐ Thermometer

☐ Basic pain and fever medicine

☐ Personal prescriptions

☐ Medication list

☐ Emergency contacts

☐ Printed first-aid instructions

☐ CPR face shield if trained

☐ Tourniquet with training

KEEP A PAPER COPY WITH THE KIT

Emergency medical information

One sheet per person

NAME	
BIRTH DATE	
CONDITIONS	
MEDICINES	
DOSAGES	
ALLERGIES	
EQUIPMENT	
DOCTOR	
PHARMACY	
CONTACT	

AVOID THESE

Common mistakes

✗ Delay calling during a life-threatening emergency.

✗ Repeatedly remove pressure from a severely bleeding wound.

✗ Put ice, butter, or grease on burns.

✗ Move someone unnecessarily when spinal injury is suspected.

✗ Give medicine without knowing what it is or checking the label.

✗ Share prescription medicine.

✗ Forget daily medications and medical equipment.

✗ Wait until medicine runs out to seek a replacement.

TRY THIS NOW

First-aid practice

Open the kit rather than simply looking at the box.

1. Find the gloves, gauze, and wound dressings.
2. Explain how you would call for help and control bleeding.
3. Check every medicine and sterile item for damage or expiration.
4. Find the paper medication and allergy lists.
5. Identify the nearest AED and who knows CPR.
6. List each household member's essential medical needs.

Replace missing or expired supplies, then schedule hands-on first-aid, CPR, AED, and bleeding-control training.

BEFORE AN EMERGENCY

Quick checklist

☐ I have a usable, regularly checked first-aid kit.

☐ I know how to call for help and control serious bleeding.

☐ I know basic wound and burn care.

☐ I have medication, allergy, condition, and contact lists.

☐ Essential prescriptions and equipment are in the plan.

☐ I know the exact requirements for refrigerated medicines.

☐ I know where the nearest AED is.

☐ At least one person has current first-aid and CPR training.

REMEMBER

The first job of first aid is not to become a doctor.

Keep a problem from becoming worse until proper help is available.

PROTECT LIFE. CONTROL THE PROBLEM. GET HELP.

Official guidance and training

Written instructions support preparedness but do not replace hands-on training or professional medical care.

American Red Cross: Life-Threatening External Bleeding (<https://www.redcross.org/take-a-class/resources/learn-first-aid/bleeding-life-threatening-external>)

American Red Cross: Burns(<https://www.redcross.org/take-a-class/resources/learn-first-aid/burns>)

American Red Cross: First-Aid Kit(<https://www.redcross.org/get-help/how-to-prepare-for-emergencies/anatomy-of-a-first-aid-kit.html>)

CDC: Emergency Prescription Planning(<https://www.cdc.gov/prepare-your-health/take-action/prescriptions.html>)

FDA: Safe Drug Use After a Natural Disaster (<https://www.fda.gov/drugs/emergency-preparedness-drugs/safe-drug-use-after-natural-disaster>)
